

KURUKSHETRA: A LIFE · 29 OCTOBER 2026

Art brief: new storylines

The game is adding new storylines (PRD §18): the night the lac house burns, rising to command in the war, and threads and episodes across a life. This brief lists the new pictures they need: test stages, fight backgrounds, scenes and two portraits. Each entry names an existing painting to match for place, light and style. Friends who step in to help in fights are drawn by the game, so they need no art.

Priority	Storyline	Images	What
1	The night the lac house burns (Act III); failure: cells and early deaths (all acts)	**9**	2 test stages (tall and wide), 3 scenes, 2 endings
2	Rising to command; holding the line against the other side's champions (Act VI)	**12**	1 test stage, 4 fight backgrounds (tall and wide), 2 scenes
3	Threads, episodes and after the war	**21**	7 test stages (tall and wide), 5 scenes, 2 portraits
Total		**42**	

Most are for storylines not built yet. The three failure pictures in Priority 1 (a cell, a prisoners' pen, a life cut short) are for a feature already in the game and can go in as soon as they arrive.

RULES

Rules and shapes

Everything in the main art brief applies: the game's warm, painterly early-historic India; no text; timber, brick and stone, no domes, spires, colonnades, Greek or East Asian forms, crescents, bullseyes, cube dice or European swords; violence implied, no blood; no divine figures; Draupadi always shown with dignity; made or licensed for this project, AI use noted.

Kind	Size	Notes
Test stage, tall	1080×1920 (9:16)	Phones (upright). One of the five layouts below. No people up close: the puppets are the actors.
Test stage, wide	2560×1440 (16:9), or 2560×720 for side views	Laptops, desktops, tablets. Same place and light as the tall one. Side views scroll sideways, with calm ends.
Fight background	1080×1920 and 2560×1440	Tall: ground band across the middle, calm darker lower half. Wide: open ground across the lower third of the left two-thirds, calmer right third (layouts B and C of the main brief).
Scene	2560×1440 (16:9)	One file. The game cuts its 3:1 banner from the middle band, so keep the subject in the centre 40% of the width and the middle third of the height; calm lower half.
Portrait	900×1200 (3:4)	Head and shoulders; face in the upper third (the game crops a circle from the centre, 20% down).

Test stage layouts (tall)

Layout	What it needs
A Scene	A place seen at eye level. Quiet top 15%; an open, mid-tone middle where the game draws the target or object; a clear level ground across the lower 40% where two puppets stand left and right.
B Top-down	Seen from directly above. The middle left open for the board, plan or field the game draws on it; detail only at the edges.
C Side view	A long wall or road across the lower third, seen side-on, with pools of light and shadow: for stealth. Calm at both ends.
D Course	Looking along a road or river that runs straight up the picture; must tile seamlessly top to bottom.
E Fight	Ground band across the middle; calm, darker lower half for the cards.

All the stages delivered so far follow these layouts; match them (for example stage_lac_wall_tall, stage_chakravyuha_top_tall, stage_racetrack_tall).

PRIORITY 1 · 9 IMAGES · ACT III AND ALL ACTS

The lac house fire, and failure

Players inside the house on the night of the fire play a timed escape; those who know of the plot can first cut the fuse lines in the cellar. The fire still comes. And failure, already in the game: a player who fails a dangerous test out of their depth can now be killed or locked away. Today those moments borrow other paintings; these three give them their own.



stage_lac_fire_top_tall · stage_lac_fire_top

Test stage · layout B (top-down) · 1080×1920 and 2560×1440

Used for: The escape: a timed maze through the burning house to the tunnel.

Paint: The lac house at Varnavata seen from directly above with the roof gone: six to eight rooms of lacquered timber walls and doorways, a courtyard, a small trapdoor to the tunnel in one corner. Fire just starting at one edge, smoke drifting across. Floors plain and readable (the game draws the doors, sleepers and the spreading fire on top). No people.

Match: stage_lac_wall_tall



stage_lac_cellar_tall · stage_lac_cellar

Test stage · layout C (side view) · 1080×1920 and 2560×720

Used for: Before the fire: tracing and cutting Purochana's oil-soaked fuse lines in the cellar.

Paint: The cellar under the lac house at night, side-on: a low timber-beamed space, jars of oil and ghee, bundles of hemp and straw against a lacquered wall, one oil lamp. Leave the floor and lower wall clear: the game draws the fuse lines along them. No people.

Match: stage_lac_wall



scene_lac_fire

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: The night of the fire, before the escape, and the morning after.

Paint: The lac house at night, the first flames climbing one corner, resin glowing, sparks over the dark garden; the town asleep beyond. Seen from outside, a little way off. No figures in the fire.

Note: Same house as scene_lac and stage_lac_wall.

Match: scene_lac



end_fire

Ending scene · 2560×1440

Used for: The death ending for a player who does not get out of the fire.

Paint: The lac house at dawn, burnt to black timbers and ash, thin smoke rising into a pale sky; a single small brass lamp or bangle in the ash in the foreground. Quiet and sorrowful. No bodies.

Match: end_death



scene_cell

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: Locked away (any act before the war): the cell the player wakes in, before choosing to escape or wait. Today it borrows the outside of the palace wall.

Paint: A stone cell below a palace at night: rough brick and stone walls, an iron ring and a chain on the floor, a narrow barred opening high up with torchlight and a slice of the night sky beyond, straw, a clay water pot. Empty: no prisoner shown (the player is the one there).

Match: stage_prison_yard



scene_prisoners_pen

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: Taken by the enemy during the war. Today it borrows the war camp painting.

Paint: A prisoners' pen behind an army's lines at dusk: a stockade of sharpened bamboo and timber, captured weapons stacked outside, guards' fires and tents beyond, banners far off. Inside, trampled earth and a few huddled figures seen from behind, small and anonymous. No wounds shown.

Match: war_capture



end_cut_short

Ending scene · 2560×1440

Used for: The ending for a life cut short before the war, where the place has no fitting painting of its own.

Paint: A riverbank at dusk: a small clay lamp on the steps of a ghat, just gone out, a thin line of smoke rising from the wick; a pair of worn sandals beside it; the river wide and still, the far bank dark. Quiet and sorrowful. No people.

Match: end_river

PRIORITY 2 · 12 IMAGES · ACT VI

Rising to command

Rank in the war, the day's array on the field, and fights won by holding, never by killing. Pandava-side players hold against Karna and Duryodhana; Kaurava-side players hold against Arjuna and Bhima.



stage_vyuha_top_tall · stage_vyuha_top

Test stage · layout B (top-down) · 1080×1920 and 2560×1440

Used for: Deploying your companies into the day's array (crane, wheel, crocodile, needle) and giving orders.

Paint: Kurukshetra from high above at morning: a wide open plain of trampled earth, two armies drawn up far apart at the top and bottom edges as dense blocks of soldiers, chariots and banners. The middle of the field left open and plain: the game draws the arrays and companies there. Dust, no bodies.

Match: stage_chakravyuha_top



fight_karna_chariot_tall · fight_karna_chariot

Fight background · 1080×1920 and 2560×1440

Used for: Holding Karna's chariot until sunset.

Paint: The battlefield late in the afternoon, the sun low behind a dust haze; in the far middle distance, a great chariot with a sun banner and white horses half hidden in dust. Open, rutted ground in front for the two sides. No faces up close.

Match: fight_war_sunset_tall



fight_duryodhana_line_tall · fight_duryodhana_line

Fight background · 1080×1920 and 2560×1440

Used for: Keeping Duryodhana's division off the king's flank.

Paint: A battle line seen from your side: a low ridge of trampled earth, the enemy's elephant banner and a wall of shields far ahead in dust, your king's parasol small on a chariot at one side. Open ground in front.

Match: fight_war_chariot_tall



fight_arjuna_chariot_tall · fight_arjuna_chariot

Fight background · 1080×1920 and 2560×1440

Used for: Kaurava side: holding against Arjuna's chariot.

Paint: The battlefield at midday in hard light; in the far middle distance, a chariot with white horses and a banner bearing a monkey emblem, arrows in the air like a dark rain above it. Open ground in front. No faces.

Note: Do not show Krishna as the charioteer: keep the chariot far off and in dust.

Match: fight_war_field_tall



fight_bhima_charge_tall · fight_bhima_charge

Fight background · 1080×1920 and 2560×1440

Used for: Kaurava side: holding against Bhima's division.

Paint: A broken battle line seen from your side: overturned chariots and dropped shields on trampled earth, a great dust cloud rolling toward you from the far middle distance with a lion banner above it. Open ground in front. No bodies.

Match: fight_war_camp_tall



scene_war_council

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: Your seat at the war council; the evening orders.

Paint: A large tent at night: a low table with a cloth map of the field marked with small wooden pieces, lamps, commanders seen from behind or in shadow around it, the camp's fires through the open flap.

Note: Keep canon figures unrecognisable (backs, shadow): advisory review otherwise.

Match: war_eve



scene_command_banner

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: Promotion: receiving your company's or division's banner.

Paint: Dawn on the camp's parade ground: a company of soldiers drawn up in rows, a tall plain cloth banner on a bamboo staff being handed over in the centre, conch shells raised, dust in the low light. The receiver seen from behind (the player).

Match: war_capture

PRIORITY 3 · 21 IMAGES

Threads, episodes and after the war

A rival across a life, the hidden year in Virata, the war's night work and truce, and the years after. Any order; each comes in when its storyline is built.



stage_supply_camp_night_tall · stage_supply_camp_night

Test stage · layout C (side view) · 1080×1920 and 2560×720

Used for: The night raid on the enemy's supply carts (stealth).

Paint: The edge of an enemy camp at night, side-on: a long line of ox-carts loaded with grain sacks and arrow bundles, a guard fire at one end, torches on poles throwing pools of light, deep shadow between the carts. No people.

Match: stage_battlefield_night



stage_river_crossing_night_tall · stage_river_crossing_night

Test stage · layout D (course) · 1080×1920; wide 2560×720

Used for: Carrying orders across the river between the two camps.

Paint: A shallow river at night seen looking across and up its length: reeds and sandbanks, moonlight on the water, camp fires of both armies far off on either bank. The tall version must tile top to bottom.

Match: stage_matsya_ford_tall



stage_kichaka_hall_night_tall · stage_kichaka_hall_night

Test stage · layout C (side view) · 1080×1920 and 2560×720

Used for: Kichaka's court in Virata: moving unseen through the dancing hall at night.

Paint: Virata's dancing hall at night, side-on and empty: a polished floor, carved timber pillars, hanging cloth screens, a few lamps, a doorway at each end.

Note: Draupadi does not appear in the picture.

Match: stage_palace_corridor_tall



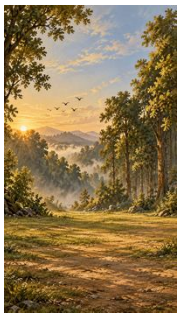
stage_virata_court_tall · stage_virata_court

Test stage · layout A (scene) · 1080×1920 and 2560×1440

Used for: Keeping your false name in King Virata's court (a test of nerve and noticing).

Paint: King Virata's audience hall by day: a low throne platform far back, courtiers small and soft at the sides, a dice board on a low table, cattle banners. Open floor in front.

Match: scene_virata



stage_exile_storm_tall · stage_exile_storm

Test stage · layout D (course) · 1080×1920; wide 2560×720

Used for: Exile: getting through a monsoon storm in the forest (a survival run).

Paint: A forest path in a monsoon storm running up the picture: driving rain, bent trees, a swollen stream crossing, lightning far off. The tall version must tile top to bottom.

Match: stage_forest_edge_tall



stage_tournament_arena_tall · stage_tournament_arena

Test stage · layout A (scene) · 1080×1920 and 2560×1440

Used for: Meeting your rival Ugra in the tournament (archery and the bout).

Paint: The tournament arena at Hastinapura by day: a sand ground, timber stands with soft crowds behind, a row of plain straw targets far back, banners. Open sand in front.

Match: scene_tournament



stage_city_ruins_tall · stage_city_ruins

Test stage · layout A (scene) · 1080×1920 and 2560×1440

Used for: After the war: rebuilding a ruined quarter of Hastinapura (clearing, sorting, steady work).

Paint: A burned city street at morning: blackened timber frames, fallen brick, a well, a cart for rubble, first new beams going up. Open ground in front. No bodies.

Match: scene_note



scene_truce_river

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: The truce at dusk: soldiers of both sides at the river.

Paint: The river at dusk between the camps: soldiers of both armies washing and filling water pots side by side, weapons laid down on the bank, banners of both sides far behind. Quiet, warm.

Match: war_day14



scene_forgiveness

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: After the war: whom to forgive.

Paint: The river at dawn after the war: two figures seen from behind, from the two sides, standing apart at the water's edge, offering water and flowers for the dead; lamps floating, mist on the river.

Note: Keep both figures anonymous (the player's choice decides who it is).

Match: scene_teaching



scene_rebuild

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: After the war: the city being rebuilt; your office.

Paint: Hastinapura months after the war: scaffolding of bamboo on timber-and-brick houses, carts of brick, workers small in the distance, a market starting again.

Match: home_hastinapura_wide



scene_student

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: Teaching a student of your own path.

Paint: A courtyard at morning: an older figure seen from behind (the player) watching a child practise (with a small bow, a staff, a palm-leaf or a lyre: keep the child's tool simple). Warm light, a tree.

Match: scene_teaching



scene_pilgrimage

Scene · 2560×1440

Used for: A pilgrimage with the elders after the war.

Paint: A mountain road above a river valley at dawn: a small group of elders and pilgrims in plain cloth walking away, staffs and bundles, a distant hermitage. Seen from behind.

Match: end_forest



p_ugra_young · p_ugra_adult

Portraits · 900×1200 (3:4) each

Used for: Ugra, the bully from the spring fair who becomes your lifelong rival: as a boy of about 12, and as a warrior of about 35.

Paint: The same face at two ages. Young: a thick-set boy, shaved head with a top knot, a wrestler's build, a challenging grin. Adult: a scarred, broad warrior in early-historic Indian war dress (quilted armour, upper cloth, no Greek helmet), the same eyes. Dark, warm background like the other portraits.

Match: p_karna

DELIVERY

Delivery and checklist

- Name every file exactly as listed; tall stages and fights end in _tall, wide ones have no suffix (stage_lac_fire_top_tall.jpg and stage_lac_fire_top.jpg).
- One zip per priority; partial batches are fine. Upload to art_review/ in the GitHub repo, or attach in the chat.
- Render at native size wherever your tool allows; if it cannot, send the native render alongside the enlarged file.
- Include a note of which pieces are AI-generated and which tool made them, for the Steam disclosure.

☐	Right shape and size: tall 1080×1920; wide 2560×1440 (side views 2560×720); portraits 900×1200
☐	JPG, sRGB; tall under 600 KB, wide under 1 MB, portraits under 300 KB
☐	Layout respected (A to E); top-down stages really from above with the middle open; course stages tile top to bottom
☐	No people up close in stages and fights; no text, signatures or watermarks
☐	Period details right; no blood; no divine figures; Draupadi not shown in the Kichaka stage; no prisoner's face shown in the cell or the pen
☐	Same place and light as the painting named under Match
☐	Made or licensed for this project; AI use noted